

Samsara, dharma, karma and moksha



The Hindu Dharmacakra, or 'wheel of life', symbolizes ***dharma***, the path to enlightenment.

Many different religious traditions arose among the early civilizations of India, but most had certain concepts in common. Now known collectively as Hinduism, these religions shared a belief in reincarnation – a cycle of birth, life, death and rebirth, called *samsara*. Along with this came a belief that liberation from this cycle can be achieved by leading a good life, so that a moral philosophy was an intrinsic part of religion.

The immortal soul, *atman*, is reborn in many forms according to *karma*, the moral law that rules the universe and determines action and reaction. The ultimate aim of life is *moksha*, release from the cycle of birth and rebirth, by devotion to God, but also through knowledge of *karma*, and especially through *dharma*, appropriate action. The idea of *dharma*, the duties and ethics necessary for leading a good life, provided a complete moral philosophy in many ways similar to that of the Greek philosophers, but inextricably connected with a religious explanation of the universe.